



AI CONNECT TRAINING SERIES

Prompt Engineering Essentials

Six techniques that improve the quality of what AI returns.



LEARNING OBJECTIVES

By the end of this session, you will be able to:

1

Give the AI clear direction

Show it an example of what you want, name the format, and show it what you are working from.

2

Get the AI's help writing your prompt

Have it ask you for the missing details before it answers.

3

Improve the AI's first draft

Have it review its own work, and take large tasks in steps you check.

One idea runs through all six techniques: give the AI what it cannot know on its own.



AGENDA

How the session is organized

PART 1

Give the AI clear direction

- 1 Show a finished example
- 2 Name the format
- 3 Show it, don't type it

PART 2

Get the AI's help writing your prompt

- 4 Have it ask you first

PART 3

Improve the AI's first draft

- 5 Have it review its draft
- 6 Split the job into steps

For each technique: concept, short demonstration, then hands-on practice.

PART 1 OF 3

Give the AI clear direction

1 · Give the AI clear direction

2 · Get the AI's help writing your prompt

3 · Improve the AI's first draft

1

TECHNIQUE 1 OF 6

Show the AI a finished example

Also called: few-shot prompting

Give the AI one or two finished examples, and ask it to do the real work the same way.

IF YOU DESCRIBE WHAT YOU WANT

The AI decides what a good answer looks like, and decides differently each time.



IF YOU SHOW WHAT YOU WANT

The AI follows the example you gave it.

Use this when the answer must follow a specific format.



SHOW A FINISHED EXAMPLE · BEFORE AND AFTER

GIVE THE AI CLEAR DIRECTION

The example decides the fields

PROMPT

Turn this incident note into a log entry.

WHAT YOU ADD: ONE FINISHED EXAMPLE

“spill in aisle 12, broken jar of sauce,
cleaned it up right away”

Type: Spill

Location: Aisle 12

Injury: None

Action: Cleaned up

“member slipped near the produce misters,
said she was fine, we put a cone out”

RESPONSE, WITHOUT THE ADDITION

Date: Not specified · Severity: Low

Description: Member slipped near
produce misters · Status: Resolved

RESPONSE, WITH THE ADDITION

Type: Slip

Location: Produce

Injury: None reported

Action: Cone placed

Without the addition, the AI invents its fields. With it, the fields are yours.



SHOW A FINISHED EXAMPLE

Your turn

THREE INCIDENT NOTES

1. "member bumped into a display near the freezers, said he was okay, we put the display back"
2. "cart corral came loose in the wind, moved it back and secured it"
3. "bakery case door not closing properly, told maintenance"

Also posted in the chat, ready to copy.

Four minutes. Then paste one of your lines into the chat.

GIVE THE AI CLEAR DIRECTION

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Take note 1 and type it out as a tidy log entry. You choose the labels.
- 2 Underneath, paste notes 2 and 3 exactly as they are.
- 3 Add: "Write these two the same way." Run it.

CHECK

Did notes 2 and 3 come back using your labels?

2

TECHNIQUE 2 OF 6

GIVE THE AI CLEAR DIRECTION

Name the format you want back

Also called: structured output prompting

Tell the AI the exact form the answer should take, and what belongs in each part of it.

IF YOU LEAVE THE FORMAT OPEN

You get paragraphs, laid out differently every time.



IF YOU NAME THE FORMAT

You get the columns you asked for, ready to use.

Use this when you plan to work with the answer somewhere else.



Name the columns and the columns come back

PROMPT

Here are this week's club comments:

"long wait at the deli on Saturday"

"produce looked great this week"

"self-checkout kept freezing"

WHAT YOU ADD: THE FORMAT, BY NAME

Put them in a table with three columns:

Comment, Area, Positive or negative.

RESPONSE, WITHOUT THE ADDITION

"Members raised a few points this week. There was a long wait at the deli on Saturday. The produce section was well received. Some members experienced repeated freezing at self-checkout."

RESPONSE, WITH THE ADDITION

Comment	Area	Positive?
Long wait at the deli	Deli	Negative
Produce looked great	Produce	Positive
Self-checkout freezing	Front end	Negative

Without the addition, prose you can only read. With it, a table you can sort.



NAME THE FORMAT · NOT ONLY TEXT

GIVE THE AI CLEAR DIRECTION

A paragraph of policy becomes a flowchart

PROMPT

Here is our overtime section:

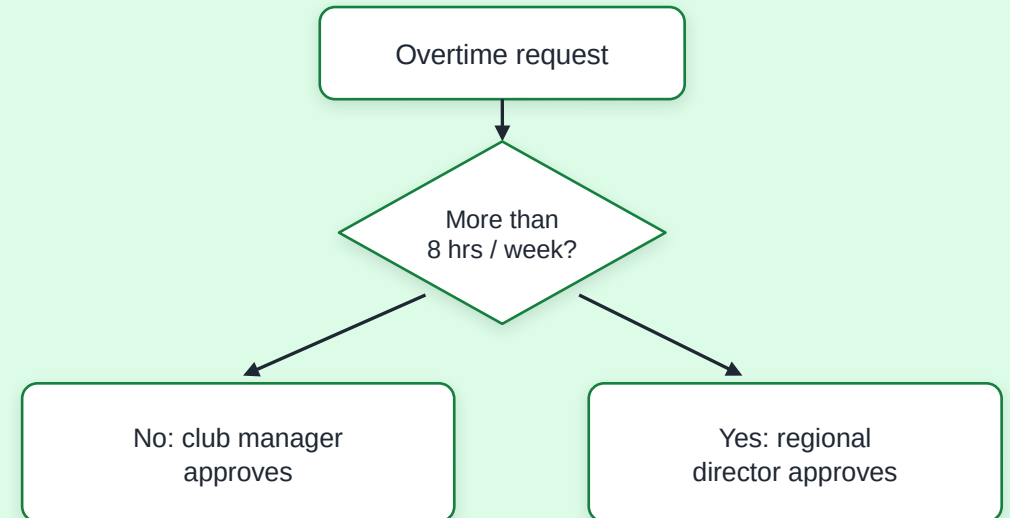
“Club managers approve overtime for their own department up to eight hours per associate per week. Requests above that go to the regional director.”

WHAT YOU ADD

Draw this as a flowchart a new club manager could follow.



RESPONSE



The same technique. You named the format, and the format happened to be a diagram.



GIVE THE AI CLEAR DIRECTION

“self-checkout froze twice on my visit”

Four minutes. Then paste one row into the chat.

Run it. Then ask for the same answer as CSV.

Does the CSV version paste into your spreadsheet as separate columns?

3

TECHNIQUE 3 OF 6

Show it, don't type it

Also called: multimodal prompting

Give the AI a photo or screenshot of what you are working from, instead of typing a description of it.

IF YOU DESCRIBE WHAT YOU SEE

You retype from memory, and whatever you leave out is gone.



IF YOU SHOW WHAT YOU SEE

The AI reads all of it, including what you would not have thought to mention.

Use this when the material is on paper, on a whiteboard, or on your screen.



SHOW IT, DON'T TYPE IT · BEFORE AND AFTER

GIVE THE AI CLEAR DIRECTION

The photo carries what memory drops

PROMPT

Typed from memory, ten minutes later:

From today's huddle: Mike is ordering totes for 219, Dana is fixing self-checkout by Wednesday, and ops is on the bakery rolls problem.

Turn this into an action list.

WHAT YOU DO INSTEAD

[photo of the whiteboard, attached]

Turn this into an action list with owners and dates.

FROM THE TYPED VERSION

1. Order totes for 219, Mike
2. Fix self-checkout, Dana, Wednesday
3. Bakery rolls problem, Operations

FROM THE PHOTO

1. Order totes for 219, Mike, Friday
2. Fix self-checkout, Dana, Wednesday
3. Bakery rolls fix, Operations, month end
4. Confirm holiday staffing, Priya, Friday
5. Send reset photos to region, Sam, Monday

The whiteboard had five actions. Three survived the retyping. The photo carried all five.



SHOW IT, DON'T TYPE IT

Your turn

SCREENSHOT THIS PANEL

WEEK 34 HUDDLE

- totes for 219, Mike, Fri
- self-checkout fix, Dana, Wed
- bakery rolls, ops, month end
- holiday staffing, Priya
- reset photos to region, Sam

Also posted in the chat, ready to copy.

Four minutes. Then post one row into the chat.

GIVE THE AI CLEAR DIRECTION

WHAT TO DO

1

Screenshot the panel on the left. Snipping Tool works.

2

Paste the screenshot into Claude or ChatGPT with: "Turn this into a table with columns Action, Owner, Due."

3

Check the table against the panel. Count the rows.

CHECK

Five rows, with owners and dates read straight off the image?

PART 2 OF 3

Get the AI's help writing your prompt

1 · Give the AI clear direction

2 · Get the AI's help writing your prompt

3 · Improve the AI's first draft



TECHNIQUE 4 OF 6

GET THE AI'S HELP WRITING YOUR PROMPT

Have the AI ask you first

Also called: meta-prompting

Ask the AI to put questions to you, or to improve your prompt, before it writes anything.

IF YOU ASK STRAIGHT AWAY

The AI writes around the details it does not have.



IF THE AI ASKS YOU FIRST

You supply those details, and the answer is built on them.

Use this when the task depends on details only you know.



HAVE IT ASK YOU FIRST · BEFORE AND AFTER

GET THE AI'S HELP WRITING YOUR PROMPT

One sentence turns it into an interview

PROMPT

Draft an email to my team about the new inventory count schedule starting in September.

WHAT YOU ADD: ONE SENTENCE

Before you write, ask me the five questions you need answered.

RESPONSE, WITHOUT THE ADDITION

"Team, starting in September we will move to the new inventory count schedule. Please review the updated calendar and plan coverage for your area. More details to follow."

RESPONSE, WITH THE ADDITION

1. Which departments does this affect?
2. What changes from the current schedule?
3. What are the key dates?
4. What must people do first?
5. How formal should the email be?

Without it, fine wording around guessed details. With it, five questions, and the email is built on your answers.



HAVE IT ASK YOU FIRST

Your turn

A REQUEST WITH THE DETAILS MISSING

“Write a short note to my team explaining that we are changing how we handle a recurring request, starting next month.”

The change, the team, the timing and the reason are all missing. Only you can supply them, so pick a real one from your own work.

Also posted in the chat, ready to copy.

GET THE AI'S HELP WRITING YOUR PROMPT

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Type the request as it stands. Read what comes back.
- 2 Type it again, adding: “Before you write, ask me the five questions you need answered.”
- 3 Answer its questions, then let it write the note.

CHECK

Is the second version something you could actually send?

Five minutes. Then share in the chat one question it asked that you had not thought of.

PART 3 OF 3

Improve the AI's first draft

3

1 · Give the AI clear direction

2 · Get the AI's help writing your prompt

3 · Improve the AI's first draft



Have the AI review its own draft

Also called: self-refine

Ask the AI to read what it just wrote as your reader will, and name what that reader would still ask.

THE FIRST DRAFT

Usually accurate and well written. It covers what you gave it.



AFTER THE REVIEW

It also covers what you did not give it, and what your reader will ask next.

Use this before your work goes to a wider audience.



The reader's questions, before the reader asks them

PROMPT

Write a short update for leadership from these notes.

“10 of 12 clubs trained. 331 not scheduled. Login issue fixed 8 August. Need a decision on September clubs.”

THE FOLLOW-UP YOU TYPE

Review this as a director with two minutes. What would they ask that this does not answer? Then rewrite it.

THE FIRST DRAFT

“Pilot update: 10 of 12 clubs have completed training. Club 331 remains unscheduled. The login issue was resolved on 8 August. A decision is needed on September clubs.”

AFTER THE FOLLOW-UP

A director would ask: when is the decision needed by? Why is 331 unscheduled, and who owns it? What slips if we wait?

None of that is in the notes. Add it, or say it is being confirmed.

The draft was accurate. The review found what the notes never contained.



HAVE IT REVIEW ITS DRAFT

Your turn

IMPROVE THE AI'S FIRST DRAFT

NOTES TO WRITE UP

“Two of the four pilot clubs finished the new receiving process this week. One is waiting on equipment. The fourth has not started because the manager is on leave. Costs are tracking to plan. We need a call on whether to add clubs in October.”

Also posted in the chat, ready to copy.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Ask for a short update for leadership from these notes.
- 2 Then type: “Review this as a director with two minutes. What would they ask that this does not answer? Then rewrite it.”
- 3 Compare the two versions.

CHECK

Which of its questions could you not answer from the notes?

Four minutes. Then post one of those questions into the chat.



TECHNIQUE 6 OF 6

IMPROVE THE AI'S FIRST DRAFT

Split one job into a few prompts

Also called: prompt chaining

Work through a large task one prompt at a time, so you can see and correct the middle of it.

IF YOU ASK FOR EVERYTHING AT ONCE

You get a finished answer with no way to see what was left out on the way.



IF YOU WORK IN STEPS

You see every item before it is grouped, and can correct a step instead of the whole job.

Use this when it matters that nothing was quietly dropped.



Steps make the middle visible

PROMPT

1. "List every issue in these notes.
One line each."
2. "Group those issues into three themes.
Name each theme."
3. "Write a leadership summary using those
themes. Under 150 words."

Three prompts, run one after another in the same conversation.

THE SAME JOB AS ONE GIANT PROMPT

"Three themes across the six clubs: staffing at peak, equipment reliability, and signage. Recommend prioritizing tire bay waits at 331 and the freezer seal at 587."

WHAT YOU SEE AT EACH STEP

AFTER STEP 1

Nineteen issues, one line each. You add two that were missed.

AFTER STEP 2

Three themes. You move two wrongly grouped issues.

AFTER STEP 3

The same summary, built on nineteen issues, not eleven.

The one-prompt summary used eleven of nineteen issues, and nothing showed which eight were missing.



SPLIT THE JOB INTO STEPS

Your turn

IMPROVE THE AI'S FIRST DRAFT

NOTES FROM FOUR CLUB VISITS

"219: self-checkout freezing Saturdays, deli short staffed at lunch, produce reset looks good.

331: tire bay waits over an hour, no online booking, signage for the new layout unclear.

104: parking lot lighting out in two rows, bakery out of rolls Sunday, staff praised by members.

587: freezer door seal failing, checkout queues long at 5pm, new signage working well."

Also posted in the chat, ready to copy.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Paste the notes and ask: "List every issue in these notes, one line each." Read the list.
- 2 Then: "Group those issues into three themes and name each theme." Check the themes.
- 3 Then: "Write a summary using those themes, under 150 words."

CHECK

Count the issues in step 1. Did anything get lost by step 3?

Five minutes. Read each answer before running the next step.



BEFORE YOU GO

Four habits you can retire, and what replaced them

“You are a world-class expert...” → Name the reader instead, for example a busy club manager.

“Think step by step” → Current models already reason. Ask to see the plan if you want to check it.

Unusually polite or forceful wording → Neither changes the answer. State what you want plainly.

Writing very long prompts → Length is not the same as clarity. A few clear lines are usually enough.

These were all real techniques. Newer models handle them internally. The six in this session still make a difference.



WHAT YOU CAN NOW DO

The three things we set out to learn



Give the AI clear direction

You showed it a finished example, named your format, and pasted a screenshot instead of typing a description.



Get the AI's help writing your prompt

You had it ask you for the missing details before it answered.



Improve the AI's first draft

You had it review its own work, and took a large task in checked steps.



WHAT'S NEXT

Choose one technique to use this week

Pick the one that fits a task already on your list. Prompt Engineering Advanced covers reusable prompts, connectors and longer multi-step work.